WEEK 10 | THE CRYSTAL BALL BRIEF

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1. My angle

My job is to find the assumption that kills the idea, not to sell a product. Our debate challenged all four vacuums. The broad Buyer's Agent lacked proven demand and risked manipulation; Regret Prevention confused fewer returns with better decisions; Tiendita Digitization had real adoption evidence, but adoption did not prove higher net profits. We first ranked tienditas highest, then corrected that mistake. We chose Debt Guardrails conditionally because unexpected fees and missed obligations are more specific outcomes—not because an AI business has been proved. A serious problem is not always an information problem; measurable harm is not always preventable harm.

2. The technology, honestly

Today, ordinary software can calculate balances, fees, due dates and repayment overlaps. AI can extract figures from statements and explain terms in plain language, but those outputs need checking. Neither a chatbot nor a credit report can reliably discover every debt across Mexican lenders and informal borrowing. Article 76 creates a financial-data-sharing framework, not guaranteed universal access [7]. The 2025 privacy law requires express consent for financial personal data, subject to exceptions [8]. AI cannot reliably judge whether borrowing for food, work or an emergency is a "bad" choice. If a calculator, calendar or simple alert performs equally well, I would reject the AI agent. A UK FCA field experiment found some overdraft alerts reduced charges but other early warnings did not; that evidence does not establish the same effects for Mexican BNPL [6].

3. The world's best attempt — GLOBAL → LOCAL

ClearScore (UK): shows reported debts together in a free Total Debt Overview [2]. It gets visibility right, but reported records may omit obligations, and credit-partner commissions create a potential incentive conflict, even though ClearScore says commissions do not determine rankings [3]. In Mexico, the service would need explicit coverage limits and support for missing or manually entered debts.

Undebt.it (US): offers manual debt entry and snowball/avalanche repayment plans without a required bank login; optional paid AI features now exist [4]. It proves basic planning need not require generative AI. Manual records can become stale, and planning cannot create repayment capacity. Mexico would need variable-income options, local repayment formats and clear uncertainty labels.

StepChange Debt Charity (UK): provides free debt advice and human-supported pathways, not just a dashboard. It reports advising 170,928 clients in 2024, an organizational outcome claim, not an independent causal effect [5]. Its reliance on funding and UK-specific debt pathways cannot be copied directly; Mexico would need local support partners, lawful options and sustainable independent funding.

4. The vacuum I'd attack

Debt Guardrails, as a testable hypothesis: some Mexican borrowers may face avoidable costs when repayment information is fragmented or late. ENSAFI 2023 reports 48.4% of adults very worried about accumulating debt and 36.9% with high financial stress [1]. Financial stress proves the importance of the problem, not demand for another financial product. It does not show how often people misunderstand debts, especially when low income leaves no alternative. I would test whether a verified debt summary reduces unexpected fees or overlooked payment conflicts, compared with existing statements and a non-AI calendar, over 60–90 days. Buyers define the outcomes; less borrowing alone is not success. This experiment has not been conducted.

Kill the standalone AI business if: correct information does not improve meaningful buyer-defined outcomes; simpler tools work as well; data gaps make advice misleading; or no payer can cover costs without promoting borrowing or exploiting personal data. Demand, retention, willingness to pay and commercial viability remain unproven.

5. The shadow

The danger in Isle of Happiness is protection becoming control. A buyer-aligned agent could reproduce the seller's manipulation and surveillance by deciding which purchases someone "deserves." My design decision is User-Defined, Reversible Commitments. The AI may never independently create, extend or reinterpret a spending restriction, or label purchases essential/nonessential. A user may explicitly set an amount, duration and covered payment method after clear explanations and informed consent, but enforcement is possible only through authorized, supported payment integrations. Users need a defined review and emergency-revocation process. Its exact override mechanism remains untested; a restriction must never silently become permanent.

6. My opening position for Team Bending

I reject the professor's claim that Mexican return rates prove personalization has made consumers measurably worse at deciding. Seller conversion incentives can conflict with buyer interests, but returns can also reflect sizing errors, defects, easier policies or legitimate changes of mind. Correlation is not causation; the quoted return-rate comparison and its link to personalization were not verified. My opening bet is test Debt Guardrails first, and be ready to kill it. Protecting a buyer means preserving their real choices, not making decisions for them.

REFERENCES | Clickable source links

[1] INEGI & CONDUSEF (2024). ENSAFI 2023, official results.

[2] ClearScore. Total Debt Overview.

[3] ClearScore. How Does ClearScore Make Money?

[4] Undebt.it. Pricing, Features & Reviews.

[5] StepChange Debt Charity. 2024 Impact Report.

[6] Financial Conduct Authority (2018). Time to Act: A Field Experiment on Overdraft Alerts.

[7] Mexico, Cámara de Diputados. Fintech Law, Art. 76.

[8] Mexico, Cámara de Diputados. Personal Data Protection Law (2025), Art. 7.